

Horizon	Description
O–Horizon (Organic horizon) Humus	It consists of fresh or partially decomposed organic matter. O1 – Freshly fallen leaves, twigs, flowers and fruits O2 – Dead plants, animals and their excreta decomposed by micro-organisms. Usually absent in agricultural and deserts.
A–Horizon (Leached horizon) Topsoil - Often rich in humus and minerals.	It consists of top soil with humus, living creatures and in-organic minerals. A1 – Dark and rich in organic matter because of mixture of organic and mineral matters. A2 – Light coloured layer with large sized mineral particles.
B-Horizon (Accumulation horizon) (Subsoil-Poor in humus, rich in minerals)	It consists of iron, aluminium and silica rich clay organic compounds.
C - Horizon (Partially weathered horizon) Weathered rock Fragments - Little or no plant or animal life.	It consists of parent materials of soil, composed of little amount of organic matters without life forms.
R – Horizon (Parent material) Bedrock	It is a parent bed rock upon which underground water is found .

Figure 6.7: Soil Profile

Soil Profile

Soil is commonly stratified into horizons at different depth. These layers differ in their physical, chemical and biological properties. This succession of super-imposed horizons is called soil profile.

Types of soil particles

Based on the relative proportion of soil particles, four types of soil are recognized.

	Soil type	Size	Relative proportion
1	Clayey soil	Less than 0.002 mm	50% clay and 50% silt (cold / heavy soil)
2	Silt soil	0.002 to 0.02mm	90% silt and 10% sand
3	Loamy soil	0.002 to 2mm	70% sand and 30 % clay / silt or both (Garden soil)
4	Sandy soil	0.2 to 2 mm	85% sand and 15% clay (light soil)

Table 6.3: Types of soil particles

Loamy soil is ideal soil for cultivation. It consists of 70% sand and 30% clay or silt or both. It ensures good retention and proper drainage of water. The porosity of soil provides adequate aeration and allows the penetration of roots.

Based on the water retention, aeration and mineral contents of soil, the distribution of vegetation is divided into following types.

1. **Halophytes:** Plants living in saline soils
2. **Psammophytes:** Plants living in sandy soils
3. **Lithophytes:** Plants living on rocky surface
4. **Chasmophytes**: Plants living in rocky crevices
5. **Cryptophytes**: Plants living below the soil surface
6. **Cryophytes**: Plants living on surface of ice
7. **Oxylophytes**: Plants living in acidic soil
8. **Calciphytes**: Plants living in calcium rich alkaline soil.

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